Life and Works

John Stuart ***Mill*** was born on 20 May 1806 in Bentonville, a northern suburb of London to Harriet Barrow and James ***Mill***, a Scotsman who was educated at Edinburgh University. The development of John Stuart ***Mill*** as a social and political thinker can be divided into three specific periods. The first period represents the training that he received from his childhood under both his father, James ***Mill*** and Jeremy Bentham. The second period marks his recovery from his mental crisis which started in his early twenties, with the termination and dissolution of the philosophic radicals as a distinct party towards the end of the 1830s. It was at this period that ***Mill*** refashioned his thinking under a variety of intellectual and emotional influences. The final period which extends to over thirty years of his career, marks the time in which he published his major works that included, A System of Logic, Principles of Political Economy, On Liberty and Considerations on Representative Government.

On Liberty

On Liberty (1859) brought ***Mill*** enduring fame, and predicted that among all his works, this was destined to survive the longest. The transformation of society from aristocratic to democratic forms of organization brought with it both advantages and disadvantages. It meant rule by social masses that would be more powerful, uniform and omnipresent than the rulers of previous eras. ***Mill*** held that, the dominance of the majority carried with it more risks that from a monarch that had the capacity to place restrictions over the freedoms of individuals, which could be legislatively enacted. Informal mechanisms of social pressure and expectation could in democratic societies could be all-controlling. ***Mill*** expressed that such powers could have the capacity of stifling conformism in thought, character and action. In was in this context that On Liberty was written. The aims of this work is written in the first chapter which asserts one simple principle. This principle states that "the sole end for which mankind are warranted, individually or collectively, in interfering with the liberty of action of any of their number, is self-protection" (Liberty: XVIII 223). Thus, the practical philosophy of this argument by ***Mill*** is primarily utilitarian.

In his 'On Liberty' ***Mill*** puts forward different strategies to argue for freedom of thought and discussion, character, and action. Freedom of thought and discussion are discussed in chapter two of On Liberty, where arguments against the control of expression are explained. Chapter three of On Liberty, puts forward argument in favour of freedom of Character (individuality) where such arguments are two pronged. On the one hand ***Mill*** argues for freedom of space for individuals which individuals should have to develop their own character while on the other, he maintains that it is best for society too. "Human nature is not a machine to be built after a model, and set to do exactly the work prescribed for it, but a tree, which requires to grow and develop itself on all sides, according to the tendency of the inward forces which make it a living thing" (Liberty,

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